cremated remains. Excavations have revealed a lot of miniature stone and brick stupas in at least one temple's courtyard.

A great many questions remain unanswered. It's not clear how many nuns were at Nalanda, and how they lived. Who provided all the basic services? Or as the scholar Frederick M. Asher asked, 'Who were the cooks and barbers, the sweepers and sculptors, the cloth-workers who prepared the monks' garments, if they were not monks? Did they remain within Nalanda's walls, or did they go home at night to a residence within an easy walking commute to the monastery?' It's also not clear whether the laity was allowed to visit the temples within Nalanda. The high wall around the Mahavihara suggests that public access was controlled. Perhaps the laity could only visit the few temples outside the wall. Perhaps they could visit the temples inside on selected festival days, but we can't be sure. What's also strikingly missing from the pilgrims' accounts is any sense of what these cloistered and bookish monks gave back to the villagers who in fact underwrote their lifestyle.

The monks' lives, it seems, weren't relentlessly austere. The discovery of dice suggests secular diversions. Perhaps there were physical games too. The canonical Cullavagga text cites monks in the early Buddhism of fourth century BCE as 'engaged in board games, parlor games, dicing, tumbling, shooting marbles, riding, and swordsmanship'—so why not also at Nalanda?[13] Yijing also makes a tantalizing reference to ceremonies where 'a band of girls plays music'. But so much remains opaque. How many of the young monks, I wonder, felt the stirrings of sexual desire after joining Nalanda and struggled with it steeped in guilt; how many decided to quit the monastic life to seek marital union or worldly riches? And we can only speculate about the darker side of Nalanda's social life: sexual abuse, personal jealousies, political rivalries and so on.